

CLUE & CANDLE GAMES PRESENTS

A Very Merry *Murder*

A Cozy Christmas Murder Mystery Party Game

6-16 PLAYERS

90 MIN-2.5 HOURS

PRINTABLE PDF



Host Guide



CLUE & CANDLE GAMES

LETTER + A4 · 12 CHARACTER BOOKLETS



You can host this

You don't need any experience to host this. Follow this guide from top to bottom and you'll be ready.

The story

It is Christmas Eve at Snowbury Lodge, and the Frost & Fable Toy Company is having its annual party. The founder, **Nicholas "Nick" Frost**, raises his favourite red mug for the 9 o'clock toast. Forty minutes later he collapses beside the Christmas tree and never wakes up. The snow has closed the only road. Nobody can leave, and somebody in the room did it. **Inspector Noel** (that's you, the host) has until morning to find out who.

How the game works

1. **Before the party:** assign a character to each guest and send their invitation (costume idea included).
2. **Opening scene (5 min):** read Script 1. Nick has just collapsed.
3. **Three rounds (25–30 min each, or 20 min in the Express version):** you reveal new evidence cards. Every player's booklet gives them things to reveal, questions to ask and a mini task each round, so nobody is left standing around.
4. **Accusations (10 min):** everyone fills in a ballot: who did it, how, and why.
5. **The reveal (5 min):** you read the solution and hand out the awards.

YOUR ROLE: INSPECTOR NOEL

You run the rounds, read the scripts and ask the questions. You are in the story all evening, not stuck in the kitchen. Read the sealed solution in private beforehand if you like to steer, or keep it sealed and solve along with your guests.

TIME

The full game takes about 2 to 2.5 hours with a dinner break. The Express version (page 8) takes about 90 minutes and can be played seated around one table.



Prep checklist

Two weeks before

- ☐ Count your guests and choose the cast with the table on page 5.
- ☐ Assign a character to each guest.
- ☐ Send invitations: printed (02-Invitations.pdf), typed (Invitation-Maker.html) or by phone (E-Invites folder).

One week before

- ☐ Print the files (see page 15). Black and white is fine.
- ☐ Cut out the evidence cards and ballots. Name tags are optional.
- ☐ Fold each booklet and write the character's name on the back, or use envelopes. Players must not read other booklets.
- ☐ Plan the menu (ideas on page 14).

The day before

- ☐ Read this guide and Scripts 1–4 aloud once.
- ☐ Print 99-SOLUTION-Host-Only.pdf last, put it in an envelope and seal it.
- ☐ Optional: hang the banner, set out the photo props and labels (35-Party-Decor.pdf).

On the night

- ☐ Set out the evidence table, name tags, pens and detective notes.
- ☐ Stack the evidence cards face down in three piles: Round 1, 2 and 3.
- ☐ Hand out booklets and name tags as guests arrive.



One-hour prep plan

Everything in this kit is optional except the booklets, the evidence cards and the ballots. This is the fastest way to get ready.

STEP	WHAT TO DO	ABOUT
1	Pick your cast from the table on page 5 and send the invitation text by message (02-Invitations.pdf, page 8), with the picture invitation from the E-Invites folder if you like.	10 min
2	Print only the booklets for the roles you are using, evidence cards pages 1–2, and one ballot page per 4 players. Read this guide on screen.	15 min
3	Cut out the 12 evidence cards along the dashed lines (neighbouring cards share cut lines) and the ballots.	15 min
4	Fold each booklet in half and write the character's name on the back. No envelopes needed.	10 min
5	Read Script 1 and the run sheet once, out loud.	10 min

WHAT A 6-PLAYER GAME NEEDS

6 booklets × 4 pages = 24 pages, plus 2 evidence pages and 2 ballot pages: **28 pages**, or 14 sheets printed double-sided. Detective notes, name tags, card backs, awards and decor are all extras.

SKIP THESE AND STILL PLAY

Printed invitations (send the text instead), name tags (sticky labels work), card backs, awards, table signs and decor. You can also skip cutting: keep each evidence page folded so only the current round shows, and read the cards aloud.



Choosing the cast

The six **core** characters are always needed. Add optional characters in the order below. All the key evidence is on the evidence cards, so the mystery stays solvable however many optional characters you use. Every role works for anyone: names and costumes are gender-neutral.

PLAYERS	CAST
6	Core only: Robin Holly, Jordan Tinsel, Sam Garland, Casey Sleigh, Alex Snow, Morgan Ivy
7	+ Taylor Star (the hired Santa)
8	+ Charlie Bell (marketing manager)
9	+ Frankie Fir (the gardener)
10	+ Quinn Mistletoe (the journalist)
11	+ Jamie Pudding (the village baker)
12	+ Riley Carol (the hired pianist)
13–16	All 12 roles. Couples or friends share a role as a pair (two Caseys from Sleigh Bells Catering, Santa and an elf as Taylor), or extra guests play Deputy Detectives with their own brief (file 33).

CASTING NOTE

The host plays only Inspector Noel. Give every character role, core and optional, to a guest.

WHY THE OPTIONAL ROLES MATTER

Each optional character is an eyewitness. They hold a detail that backs up the evidence cards, plus their own secret, goals, questions and a mini task every round. With more of them playing, the case comes together faster and the room stays busier.

DEPUTY DETECTIVES

Extra guests get a name tag, a detective notes sheet, a Deputy Detective brief (file 33, page 2) and a ballot. They help Inspector Noel question the suspects.



Removable characters

Drop optional characters from the bottom of the list first. Nothing essential is lost: every fact needed to solve the case is printed on the evidence cards.

CHARACTER	TYPE	DROP ORDER	IF LEFT OUT
Robin Holly	Core	Never	Keep this role
Jordan Tinsel	Core	Never	Keep this role
Sam Garland	Core	Never	Keep this role
Casey Sleigh	Core	Never	Keep this role
Alex Snow	Core	Never	Keep this role
Morgan Ivy	Core	Never	Keep this role
Taylor Star	Optional	6th	Safe to remove
Charlie Bell	Optional	5th	Safe to remove
Frankie Fir	Optional	4th	Safe to remove
Quinn Mistletoe	Optional	3rd	Safe to remove
Jamie Pudding	Optional	2nd	Safe to remove
Riley Carol	Optional	1st	Safe to remove

Last-minute changes

- **An optional player cancels:** leave their booklet out. Nothing else changes.
- **A core player cancels:** move an optional player into the core role and drop their optional role.
- **Only five people turn up:** read the missing core character's booklet lines aloud at the start of each round as "a statement given to the Inspector".
- **Extra guests arrive:** let them share a role or play Deputy Detectives.



Run sheet: the full party

TIME	WHAT HAPPENS	YOU DO
0:00	Guests arrive, drinks, costumes, photos	Hand out booklets and name tags. Players read the cover and "Before the game" only
0:15	Opening scene	Read Script 1
0:20	Round 1	Reveal Evidence 1–4 . Players read Round 1, then mingle, reveal, ask and do their mini task
0:50	Dinner or snacks	Players stay in character if they like. A good moment for your real gift swap
1:20	Round 2	Read Script 2 , reveal Evidence 5–8 . Players read Round 2
1:50	Round 3	Read Script 3 , reveal Evidence 9–12 . Players read Round 3
2:20	Accusations	Read Script 4 . Hand out ballots; allow 5–10 minutes
2:30	The reveal	Open the sealed solution and read Script 5 . Give out awards

HOW TO REVEAL EVIDENCE

Read the card aloud, then put it face up on the evidence table where everyone can look at it.

KEEPING EACH ROUND BUSY

Each booklet round has things to reveal, two questions to ask and a mini task. Use the interrogation prompts under each script to question suspects yourself. Call a two-minute warning before each new round.

What players read, and when

WHEN	PLAYERS OPEN	EVIDENCE ON THE TABLE
On arrival	Booklet cover and "Before the game"	None yet
Script 1	Round 1	#1–4
Script 2	Round 2	#1–8
Script 3	Round 3, "Before you vote" and notes	#1–12
Script 4	A ballot	All 12 cards



Express version

For a shorter evening, older guests or a work lunch. Same story, same evidence, same solution. Everyone can stay seated at one table: instead of mingling, players take turns asking their questions across the table.

TIME	WHAT HAPPENS	YOU DO
0:00	Arrival	Hand out booklets. Players read the cover and "Before the game"
0:10	Opening + Round 1	Read Script 1 , reveal Evidence 1–4 . 20 minutes
0:30	Round 2	Read Script 2 , reveal Evidence 5–8 . 20 minutes, with snacks on the table
0:50	Round 3	Read Script 3 , reveal Evidence 9–12 . 20 minutes
1:10	Accusations	Read Script 4 . 5 minutes to fill in ballots
1:15	The reveal	Read Script 5 and give out awards. Done by about 1:30

EXPRESS TIPS

- Go round the table: each player shares one "Reveal or gossip" line and asks one question, then the next player goes.
- Mini tasks are optional in Express. Skip them if time is tight.
- Read every evidence card aloud and pass it round the table.
- With 6–8 players, 15 minutes per round is often enough.

SEATED-FRIENDLY

Nobody needs to stand, walk around or read in a dim room. The booklets use 11pt type, and the host can read lines aloud for anyone who prefers not to.



Script 1: Opening

"Good evening, everyone. My name is Inspector Noel. I came to Snowbury Lodge tonight as somebody's plus-one, for eggnog and carols. I did not come to work.

But twenty minutes ago, at 9:40, our host Nicholas Frost, founder of the Frost & Fable Toy Company, collapsed beside the Christmas tree. I'm sorry to tell you that Nick has died. He was perfectly well at the 9 o'clock toast.

The snow has closed the road, the phone lines are down, and nobody is leaving this lodge tonight. I believe one of you knows exactly what happened to Nick. Each of you has a secret, and I intend to hear all of them.

Talk to each other. Ask questions. You can keep your own secrets for now, but you may not lie about the evidence. Here's what we know so far."

(Reveal Evidence 1–4. Players now read Round 1.)

EVIDENCE TO REVEAL THIS ROUND

- #1 The Doctor's Note
- #2 The Mug and the Bowl
- #3 The Gift Tag
- #4 A Notebook Page

ROUND CHECKLIST

- ☐ Read the script aloud.
- ☐ Reveal the cards one by one, then lay them on the evidence table.
- ☐ Tell players to open Round 1 in their booklets.
- ☐ Ask a few prompts, then give a two-minute warning.

INTERROGATION PROMPTS

- Casey, who made the eggnog, and who filled Nick's mug?
- Jordan, you carried the mug. Did you open it, or put it down anywhere?
- Whose cardigan is that by the fire? Whose notebook page?
- Alex, nobody invited you. Why are you here?

OPTIONAL FOLLOW-UPS IF IT GOES QUIET

- Who here knew how much Nick loved peppermint?
- Who saw Nick open his Secret Santa gift?
- Who benefits from Nick's will?
- Where was everyone at 9 o'clock?

Skip any prompt for a character who isn't playing tonight.



Script 2: Start of Round 2

"Thank you all for your patience, and for the sausage rolls. While you ate, I did some digging around this lodge, and Snowbury Lodge keeps better records than most police stations. There is a key log hanging in the hall, and it tells us exactly who went into the greenhouse today.

The gardener keeps a diary, and it says something was taken from that greenhouse this afternoon. I've also found a list in Morgan's handwriting, and notes from a meeting in Nick's study that somebody hoped would stay private.

Some of you have been keeping secrets from me, and these papers suggest a few of those secrets are about to come out. Read your Round 2 instructions and look at the new evidence. Remember: you may keep secrets, but you may not lie about what's on these cards."

(Reveal Evidence 5–8. Players now read Round 2.)

EVIDENCE TO REVEAL THIS ROUND

- #5 The Greenhouse Key Log
- #6 The Gardener's Log
- #7 The Secret Santa List
- #8 Meeting Notes from Nick's Study

ROUND CHECKLIST

- ☐ Read the script aloud.
- ☐ Reveal the cards one by one, then lay them on the evidence table.
- ☐ Tell players to open Round 2 in their booklets.
- ☐ Ask a few prompts, then give a two-minute warning.

INTERROGATION PROMPTS

- To each name on the key log: why did you go to the greenhouse, and what did you bring back?
- Morgan, is this Secret Santa list genuine? Could anyone have changed it?
- Jordan, what was that meeting in the study really about?
- Frankie, when did you notice the foxglove was gone, and who did you tell?

OPTIONAL FOLLOW-UPS IF IT GOES QUIET

- Who knew about the sale before tonight?
- Who loses the most if the workshop closes?
- Who put a gift under the tree for Nick, and what was it?
- Has anyone's story changed since Round 1?

Skip any prompt for a character who isn't playing tonight.



Script 3: Start of Round 3

"It's almost midnight. The snow has finally stopped, and I've been out in the grounds with a torch while you talked. Directly under one of the lodge windows I found something lying in the snow, and Father Christmas did not leave it there.

Back inside, I found something in a drawer where it had no business being, and something in a sink that should have been back in a kitchen. I've also checked some travel papers, so a few of you will find your alibis are now very strong, and a few of you may not.

This is the last round, so choose your questions carefully. When I call time, every one of you will have to put a name on a ballot."

(Reveal Evidence 9–12. Players now read Round 3.)

EVIDENCE TO REVEAL THIS ROUND

- #9 The Bottle
- #10 The Workbench Drawer
- #11 Travel Receipts
- #12 The Saucepan

ROUND CHECKLIST

- ☐ Read the script aloud.
- ☐ Reveal the cards one by one, then lay them on the evidence table.
- ☐ Tell players to open Round 3 in their booklets.
- ☐ Ask a few prompts, then give a two-minute warning.

INTERROGATION PROMPTS

- Sam and Alex, talk us through your travel receipts. When did you each arrive?
- Whose workbench is that drawer in, and who was the reindeer meant for?
- Casey, is that your saucepan? When did you last see it?
- Everyone: where were you between 9:40 and 9:50?

OPTIONAL FOLLOW-UPS IF IT GOES QUIET

- Who was in the corridor near the workshop after Nick collapsed?
- Who in this room knows plants well?
- Who in this room knows how to cook something from scratch?
- Whose story has changed the most tonight?

Skip any prompt for a character who isn't playing tonight.



Script 4: Accusations

"Time's up, everyone. The fire is low, the eggnog is gone, and I have heard more secrets tonight than in a whole year of police work. Every one of you had a reason to be cross with Nicholas Frost, but only one of you decided he would not see Christmas morning.

Take a ballot and write down who killed Nick, how they did it and why. Then write the one clue that convinced you, because good detectives show their working. Even the guilty party must fill in a ballot, so nobody can tell who is who by watching.

You have ten minutes, and you may look at the evidence table one last time. Fold your ballot and hand it to me. Then I'll open the sealed envelope and tell you what really happened at Snowbury Lodge."

(Collect the ballots. Script 5, the reveal, is in the sealed 99-SOLUTION-Host-Only.pdf.)

BALLOT CHECKLIST

- ☐ One ballot and a pen for every player, the guilty party included.
- ☐ Deputy Detectives fill one in too.
- ☐ Collect the folded ballots in a bowl or a stocking.
- ☐ Open the sealed solution envelope only now.

SCORING AT A GLANCE

3 points for the right **who**, 1 for **how**, 1 for **why**. The highest score wins Best Detective; on a tie, the best "clue that convinced you" wins. The answer key is in the sealed file.

INTERROGATION PROMPTS

- Optional closing statements: before ballots, give each player 30 seconds to say "I'm innocent because...". Core characters first.
- Ask the Deputy Detectives (if any) to share their best theory, without naming names.
- Give a two-minute warning before you collect the ballots.

OPTIONAL FOLLOW-UPS IF IT GOES QUIET

- Does anyone want to change their mind? Last chance.
- Is there one question nobody has answered yet?
- Which piece of evidence have we not talked about?

Skip any prompt for a character who isn't playing tonight.



Hosting tips

- **Quiet guest?** Ask them a direct question from their booklet: "Taylor, you were by the tree all evening. What did you see?" Or ask them to do their mini task now.
- **Someone gets stuck?** Every booklet round lists things to reveal, two questions to ask and a mini task. Point them to it.
- **Moving too fast?** Spend more time on the food, and use the optional follow-ups under each script.
- **Moving too slowly?** Give a two-minute warning, then start the next round. Or switch to the Express timings on page 8.
- **Keep the evidence visible.** Leave revealed cards face up on the evidence table so players can check details.
- **Hand out detective notes** (33-Detective-Notes.pdf) so players can track motives and alibis.
- **Combine it with your gift swap.** The story is built around a Secret Santa, so a real gift swap during the dinner break fits right in.
- **Prizes:** Best Detective (most of who, how and why right), Best Costume and Best Liar. Certificates are in 34-Awards-and-Table-Signs.pdf.

KEEP THE ANSWER SAFE

Never leave the sealed solution where guests can find it, and keep spare booklets out of sight.



Decor, costumes & menu

Setting the scene

- Hang the "A Very Merry Murder" banner and put out the photo props, drink labels and food tent cards (35-Party-Decor.pdf).
- Fairy lights, candles (LED is safest) and a small tree with a few wrapped boxes underneath.
- The "Snowbury Lodge" sign by the door and the "Evidence Table" sign on a side table.
- Props: a red mug, a small bottle tied with red ribbon and a wooden toy.

Menu ideas

WHEN	DISH
Arrival	Frost & Fable Eggnog, with an alcohol-free bowl for drivers and kids
Round 1	Snowbury Sausage Rolls (vegetarian ones work too)
Dinner break	Sleigh Bells Cheese Board with crackers, grapes and chutney
Round 3	Pudding's Bakery Mince Pies
The reveal	Jingle Bear Gingerbread and hot cocoa

Costumes and photos

Every invitation, booklet cover and the cast list give two costume options: an **easy** one from things most people own, and a **go all out** one for a vintage country-lodge look (velvet, tweed, white fur, a Santa suit). Set up a photo corner by the tree with the props, and take a group photo after the reveal.

Printing & assembly



FILE	COPIES
00-START-HERE, 01-Host-Guide	1 each, for you (or read on screen)
02-Invitations	1 per guest, or use the E-Invites / Invitation Maker
03-Cast-List	1–2, for anyone to read
10–21 Booklets (one PDF per character)	1 per player, only the roles you use
22-All-Booklets-Combined	Optional: all 12 booklets in one file
30-Evidence-Cards	1 set (pages 3–4 optional)
31-Name-Tags, 32-Accusation-Ballots	1 set; ballots 4 per page
33-Detective-Notes	1 per player; page 2 for Deputy Detectives
34-Awards-and-Table-Signs, 35-Party-Decor	Optional
99-SOLUTION-Host-Only	1, printed last, then sealed

- Use the folder that matches your paper: US-Letter or A4. Print at **Actual size / 100%**.
- Everything reads clearly in black and white.
- **Booklet option:** each booklet is 4 pages. To make a folded half-Letter or A5 booklet, choose your printer's **Booklet** setting, print double-sided (flip on short edge), then fold the sheet in half. Or simply print the 4 pages single-sided and staple them.
- Card backs are optional. You can play without them.
- The combined booklet file starts every booklet on a new sheet, so double-sided printing never puts two characters on one sheet.